

Nyctomys sumichrasti

Sumichrast's vesper rat



Length 4¼–5 in (11–13 cm)
Tail 3¼–6 in (8.5–15.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location S. Mexico to S. Central America



One of the more arboreal and brightly colored rats, this species has tawny or pinkish brown upperparts with darker hairs along the centre of the back. It has pale flanks, white underparts, a dark ring around the eye, and a brown, scaly, hairy tail. The ears are short and finely furred. On each foot the first toe is almost thumblike, developed for gripping twigs. Sumichrast's vesper rat lives in a colony, builds squirrel-like nests of twigs, leaves, and creepers, and rarely descends to the ground. It is active mainly at night, eating a variety of plants, including figs and avocados.

Parotomys brantsii

Brants's whistling rat



Length 5–6½ in (2.5–16.5 cm)
Tail 3–4¼ in (7.5–10.5 cm)
Weight 3–4 oz (85–125 g)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



Also known as the karoo rat from its arid, rocky, saltbrush habitat, this wary, diurnal species feeds on grass and other low-growing vegetation. It never wanders far from its extensive tunnel system, which can be accessed via numerous entrances. If danger threatens, it whistles loudly to warn other members of the colony. In favorable conditions, it can breed up to 4 times a year, females producing up to 4 young in each litter. Offspring mature quickly and are capable of breeding themselves when about 3 months old. Brants's whistling rat has a reddish orange nose and small yellow ears. The fur is patchy yellow and brown-black, with gray-white underparts.

Pachyuromys duprasi

Fat-tailed jird



Length 3¼–5 in (9.5–13 cm)
Tail 2¼–6½ in (5.5–16.5 cm)
Weight 1½–1¾ oz (20–50 g)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location N. Africa



A Sahara dweller, the fat-tailed jird has long, soft fur, a pointed snout, and long rear feet. Coloration is chestnut-cinnamon on the back and sides, with black tips to the hairs, shading to white underneath. The club-shaped tail contains a store of body fat for nourishment and water. This jird emerges from its burrow at dusk to search for insects such as crickets. It also eats leaves, seeds, and other plant matter.



Meriones unguiculatus

Mongolian jird



Length 4–5 in (10–13 cm)
Tail 3¼–4¼ in (9.5–11 cm)
Weight 2–2½ oz (50–60 g)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location C. Asia



Familiar as a pet, this is one of some 17 jird species of the Meriones genus that is native to Central Asia. It burrows in dry steppes and is active by day and night, summer and winter. It eats mainly seeds, storing excess in its elaborate burrow, which it may share with its mate and up to 12 young. Family members groom each other but are quick to attack a stranger. Mainly brown haired with black tips, the underparts are gray or white.

Hypogeomys antimena

Votsovotsa

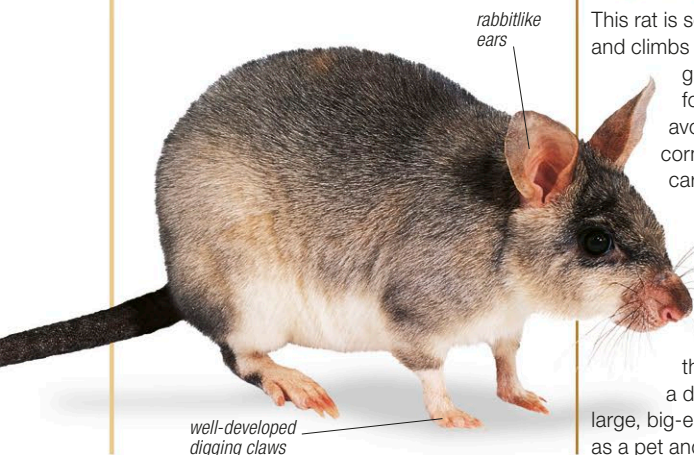


Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Tail 8½–10 in (21–25 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

Location W. Madagascar



Known locally as the votsotsa, this rat has tall, rabbitlike ears and large rear feet. Similar to a rabbit in behavior, too, it hops rather than runs and lives in a family group of male, female, and offspring of the past 2–3 years. The votsotsa digs a burrow system with up to 6 entrances in the sandy soil of coastal forests. It eats fruit, shoots, and soft bark, holding them in the forefeet. This species is threatened by habitat loss and competition from introduced roof rats.



Cricetomys gambianus

Northern giant pouched rat



Length 14–16 in (35–40 cm)
Tail 14½–18 in (37–45 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location W., C., E., and southern Africa



This rat is solitary, active mainly at night, and climbs and swims well. It eats a great variety of moist or fleshy foods, from termites to avocados, and also peanuts and corn. Its huge cheek pouches carry items back to its burrow, which has extensive chambers for food, resting, breeding, and defecation. Its bristly hair is buff-brown on the back, fading to white on the throat and underside, with a dark brown eye-ring. This large, big-eared, docile rat is kept both as a pet and for meat.

Jaculus jaculus

Lesser Egyptian jerboa



Length 4–4¼ in (10–12 cm)
Tail 6½–8 in (16–20 cm)
Weight 1½–2½ oz (45–75 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location N. Africa to W. Asia



Well adapted for desert sand, this jerboa has very long hind legs, each with 3 toes on a pad of hairs. It hops at high speed, balancing with its very long tail, which has a black band near the fluffy white tip. The fur is brown-orange on the back, gray-orange along the sides, and white below with a whitish hip band. The lesser Egyptian jerboa feeds at night on seeds, roots, and leaves. By day, it plugs the entrances to its burrow to keep out the heat, predators, and other animals.



Allactaga tetradactyla

Four-toed jerboa



Length 4–4¼ in (10–12 cm)
Tail 6–7 in (15.5–18 cm)
Weight 1¾–2 oz (50–55 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable

Location N. Africa



Each back foot of this jerboa has an extra, fourth toe, which is small compared to the 3 functional toes. In other respects it is a typical jerboa, with its huge, hopping back feet and tall, rabbitlike ears. The upperparts are speckled black and orange, the rump orange, the sides gray, and the underparts white. The long, balancing tail has a black band near the white, feathery tip. Emerging at night, the jerboa eats grass, leaves, and soft seeds.